

The written word

Humans have used spoken language for hundreds of thousands of years, but it was only around 5,000 years ago that writing was invented. Since then, people have created writing systems such as alphabets, as well as tools that allow us to write things down.



Picture words

Egyptian hieroglyphs

Where Egypt

When c. 3300 BCE to c. 394 CE

Ancient Egyptian hieroglyphics (see p.20) used around 1,000 different pictures to represent words, sounds, and objects. They fell out of use around 400 CE and remained a mystery until the discovery of the Rosetta Stone in 1799. This stone contained a text written in three languages: ancient Greek, hieroglyphics, and an ancient Egyptian script. Scholars used the Greek to work out the meaning of the hieroglyphs.

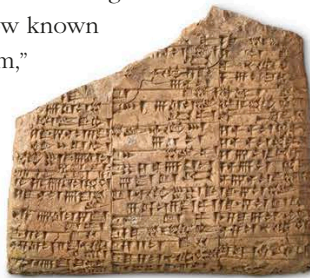
Record taking

Cuneiform

Where Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq)

When c. 3200 BCE to c. 75 CE

The Sumerians of southern Mesopotamia (see p.16) invented a writing system to keep track of business transactions. They used a sharpened reed to make indents of different shapes on a tablet made of wet clay. This writing system is now known as “cuneiform,” meaning “wedge-shaped.”



Lost symbols

Indus script

Where Indus Valley, modern-day Pakistan

When c. 2600–c. 1900 BCE

Discovered at archaeological sites in modern-day Pakistan, the Indus script was created by the Indus Valley Civilization (see p.32). The meaning of the script has been lost, but experts think that it was written from right to left and had around 400 signs, representing syllables or whole words.



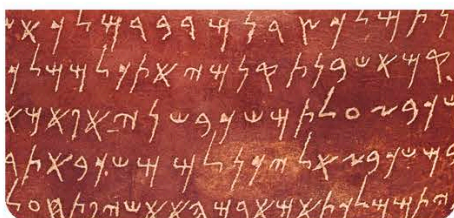
Early alphabet

Phoenician alphabet

Where Phoenicia (modern-day Lebanon)

When c. 1200–c. 900 BCE

While earlier civilizations invented writing systems that had hundreds of symbols and signs, the Phoenicians (see p.36) developed a simple alphabet, in which each symbol represented a single sound. It had 22 letters, which stood for consonants, and was the ancestor of all modern European alphabets.



Writing material

Paper

Where China

When c. 105 CE

By the 2nd century CE, papyrus (made from a reedlike plant) and parchment (made from animal skins) had long been used as writing materials, but they were expensive and decayed over time. The Chinese invented a writing material made from the pulp of plants, such as bamboo. The new material, paper, was cheap and strong, and could be mass produced easily.

